



Tracing and Evaluating Arguments

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Reading

RI.7.8

Trace the argument and specific claims in an argumentative text about extending the school year, assess whether the reasoning is sound and the evidence is relevant and sufficient, and evaluate the overall strength of the argument. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 7 · North Carolina · Reading; RI.7.8 — Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text, assessing whether the reasoning is sound and the evidence is relevant and sufficient to support the claims.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

An argument is a central claim supported by reasons and evidence. Sound reasoning means each step logically connects to the next. Relevant evidence directly supports the specific claim being made; sufficient evidence means there is enough of it to be convincing, not just one example.

Model 1 — Claim: "Our school should add a recycling program." Evidence: "My cousin's school has one." Is this evidence relevant and sufficient?

It is relevant (it relates to the claim) but not sufficient — one example from one other school is not enough evidence to strongly support a claim for a policy change.

Model 2 — Claim: "Homework should be reduced." Evidence: "A study of 500 students found reduced homework correlated with better sleep and similar test scores." Is this evidence relevant and sufficient?

Yes — it is directly relevant to the claim and, with a reasonably large sample size and specific findings, provides more sufficient support than a single anecdote would.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What is the central claim of this argument?

2. What is the first piece of evidence given to support this claim, in paragraph 1?



Should the School Year Be Longer?

1. Every summer, students lose an estimated one to two months of reading skill, a phenomenon researchers call the "summer slide." Teachers spend the first several weeks of each fall reviewing material students have partially forgotten, effectively repeating instruction that already happened the previous spring. Extending the school year would substantially reduce this wasted repetition and should be adopted nationwide.
2. Consider the numbers: a school year extended by four weeks, spread across the current ten-week summer break, would leave summer at six weeks — enough for a meaningful break while significantly narrowing the learning-loss window. Districts that have already piloted extended calendars report students returning from break with measurably smaller skill gaps than students on a traditional calendar.
3. Critics argue that extending the school year would increase costs: more days of staffing, utilities, and transportation. This is a fair concern, but it overlooks that the current system already carries a hidden cost — teachers spending weeks re-teaching lost material is not free instructional time; it is time paid for twice.
4. Other critics point to the importance of summer for family time, camps, and unstructured childhood play. These experiences matter, and a four-week extension, not year-round schooling, would preserve six weeks of summer while still shortening the learning-loss window meaningfully.
5. One pilot district extended its calendar by four weeks in 2019 and tracked outcomes for three years. Students showed a 15 percent smaller drop in reading assessment scores over the summer compared to the three years before the change, and teachers reported needing roughly two fewer weeks of fall review.
6. The evidence points in one clear direction: shortening summer break, even modestly, measurably reduces learning loss without eliminating summer's benefits. Schools that have not yet made this change are choosing a familiar calendar over a demonstrated improvement.



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says	It Means	And So
Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	Explain the evidence in your own words.	State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. Is that first piece of evidence relevant to the claim? Explain.

2. What claim does paragraph 3 respond to, and how does it respond?

3. Is the reasoning in paragraph 3 sound? Explain your evaluation.

4. What claim does paragraph 4 respond to, and how does it respond?

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. Is the evidence in paragraph 4 sufficient to fully address the concern about family time? Explain.

2. What specific evidence does paragraph 5 provide, and is it relevant to the central claim?

3. Is the evidence in paragraph 5 sufficient on its own to support extending the school year nationwide? Explain.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. What conclusion does paragraph 6 draw, and does it logically follow from the evidence presented?

2. Identify one specific claim in the argument and evaluate whether its evidence is relevant.

3. Identify one specific claim in the argument and evaluate whether its evidence is sufficient.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. Does the author acknowledge opposing viewpoints? Cite evidence.

5. Why is acknowledging opposing viewpoints generally a sign of sound reasoning?

6. Is the claim in paragraph 6 ("schools that have not yet made this change are choosing a familiar calendar over a demonstrated improvement") a fair conclusion based on the evidence? Explain.



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. What additional evidence would make the overall argument stronger?

2. Evaluate whether the reasoning connecting summer learning loss (paragraph 1) to the proposed four-week extension (paragraph 2) is logical.

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. Overall, is this argument's evidence sufficient to fully convince you the school year should be extended nationwide? Explain your evaluation.

2. How does the author's use of a specific number ("15 percent smaller drop") strengthen the argument compared to a vague claim like "students did better"?



Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Identify one specific claim, then evaluate both whether its reasoning is sound and whether its evidence is relevant and sufficient.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. That the school year should be extended (by about four weeks) because doing so would substantially reduce summer learning loss.
2. Students lose an estimated one to two months of reading skill over the summer, requiring teachers to spend weeks re-teaching material each fall.
3. Yes — it directly relates to the claim, since the summer learning loss it describes is the exact problem the proposed extension is meant to solve.
4. It responds to the claim that extending the school year would increase costs, arguing that the current system already has a hidden cost: paying teachers to re-teach lost material.
5. It is reasonably sound — it directly addresses the cost concern by reframing an existing cost (repeated instruction) as evidence the added cost may be partly offset, rather than ignoring the concern.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. It responds to the concern that summer is important for family time and unstructured play, arguing that a four-week extension still preserves six weeks of summer.
7. It is only partially sufficient — it shows some summer is preserved, but it does not provide evidence (such as a study or survey) about whether six weeks is actually enough time for meaningful family activities, which weakens this part of the argument.
8. A pilot district's three-year data showing a 15 percent smaller drop in reading scores and two fewer weeks of fall review after extending the calendar — this is directly relevant, since it provides a real-world test of the central claim.
9. It is meaningful evidence, but it comes from a single pilot district over three years — evaluating whether that is sufficient for a nationwide claim requires considering whether one district's results would generalize to different schools and communities.
10. It concludes that shortening summer break "measurably reduces learning loss without eliminating summer's benefits" — this follows reasonably from the pilot data in paragraph 5, though it may overstate certainty based on evidence from only one district.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Answers vary; for example, the claim that costs are a "hidden cost already" (paragraph 3) is relevant to the cost objection, since it directly addresses spending on instructional time.
12. Answers vary; for example, the claim in paragraph 2 that piloted districts show "measurably smaller skill gaps" is not fully sufficient on its own, since no specific numbers or district names are given in that sentence, unlike the more detailed data in paragraph 5.
13. Yes — paragraph 3 acknowledges the cost concern ("This is a fair concern") and paragraph 4 acknowledges the value of family time and play ("These experiences matter").
14. It shows the author has considered other perspectives and is responding to real concerns rather than ignoring them, which tends to make an argument more balanced and credible.
15. This is debatable — while the pilot data supports some improvement, the phrase "demonstrated improvement" may overstate certainty since the evidence comes from only one district's three-year experience, not a broader or more rigorous study.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Data from multiple districts or a larger, more diverse study, rather than a single pilot district, would make the case for a nationwide policy more convincing.

17. It is logical in its basic structure — if learning loss happens during a ten-week break, shortening that break by four weeks reasonably could reduce the amount of loss — though it assumes the relationship between break length and learning loss is roughly proportional, which is not explicitly proven.

18. Answers vary; require an evaluation that references specific evidence from the text (such as the single-district pilot data) and explains why it either does or does not feel sufficient for a nationwide claim.

19. Specific, measurable data is more convincing and harder to dismiss than a vague claim, since it gives readers a concrete result they can evaluate rather than a general impression.

20. Answers vary; require a specific claim from the text, an evaluation of its logical soundness, and an evaluation of its evidence's relevance and sufficiency, with reasoning supported by the text.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source • accessed September 18, 2026

RI.7.8 — Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text, assessing whether the reasoning is sound and the evidence is relevant and sufficient to support the claims.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 7: <https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/publications/catalog/>

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